

The Tram Horses of Leicester

Lois Edwards

During the nineteenth century, as in many of the towns and cities across Britain, Leicester's population dramatically increased. In fact the population rose by over 200,000, from 17,005 in 1801 to 219,619 in 1901. As the town expanded in both population and area, so did the demand for cheap, affordable public transport and in 1863 Solomon Andrews started a horse-drawn bus service which ran along Belgrave Road into the town centre and out the other side along London Road. Ten years later in August 1873, Leicester Corporation allowed the Leicester Tramways Company to begin a horse-drawn tram service in Leicester, and the following year on Christmas Eve 1874, the first tram ran from the Clock Tower to Belgrave. The service proved extremely successful and in 1901 the Leicester Corporation acquired the company; the size of which can be seen by looking at the assets which the Corporation purchased: 35 pair horse drawn trams, 4 single horse drawn trams, 30 pair horse buses, 4 brakes, 10 trolley and carts and 370 horses. (1) However, just three years later the trams had become electrified and the horses were sold. (2)

The life that the horses led is reflected in the *Leicester Tram Company Register* (3) and in the *Minutes of the Tramways Committee*. (4) As the horses were bought they were all

listed, along with their markings and the price paid for them; the seller was also recorded in the register. The Corporation usually bought the horses as 5 or 6 year olds with no preference for mares or geldings (listed as horses in the register). The predominant colours were bay and black, a smattering of roans and greys, however there does not appear to be any skewbald (brown and white) or piebald (black and white) horses bought. No heights were given but by looking at the images the horses appear to be around 15 to 16 hands and quite well-built. (5) The eventual fate of the horses was also recorded and the reason for sale is often recorded alongside. The horses were bought from dealers across England: Mr Creech a dealer from Bristol, and Mr Williamson from Leeds were frequently mentioned. Other horses were bought more locally, including some from H. H. German of Ashby-de-la-Zouch. Typical of the entries in the register is a bay mare, with 4 black legs, aged 6, bought from J Creech of Bristol. She was bought on 8th August 1898 for £42 and sold to a Mr Beck four years later for £7 10s. 0d., a loss of £34 10s. 0d.

An 1893 plan shows the stabling which was used for the horses. (6) It was in that year that the new stable yard was designed for the Leicester Tram Company. This was located



Trams along Humberstone Gate, Leicester in the 1890s. Here the horses are matched pairs. (Reproduced by permission of ROLLR, location mark DE3736 Humberstone Gate).

off Grape Street in Leicester, north-west of the Clock Tower. The design allowed stabling for 120 horses, with a further 6 spacious loose boxes situated by the cottage also on site. The stables were in blocks of twenty stables, and in rows of 10, facing each other. The dimensions of the stables, being just over 5 feet wide, suggest that they were in fact stalls. The horses would have been led in and tied loosely to a tie ring in the wall that allowed the horse movement in its head and neck. The horses faced the wall and ate from a trough in front of them. Although the area was not big enough to allow the horse to lie down, it was quite a common way of keeping horses that had to work for a living, as it used the space efficiently. The whole of the yard was under cover which provided a dry and wind-free area to work in. Indicated on the plan are feed bins of corn and oatmeal. A steaming tank and a gruel tank are also marked. The hay store was three stories high, an indication of the amount of hay that 120 horses would need. A walled area in the centre of the yard was for the collection of the manure. This would keep the yard clean and the muck-heap would be presumably cleared out every day. The men were not forgotten as a mess room that was heated by steam pipes can also clearly be seen on the plan.

As with all animals, some horses were more suited to the work than others, and many were still working for the tram company ten years after being bought. Many of the horses were sold to private individuals, for presumably lighter work, but almost all the horses were sold at a loss. The worn-out tram horse would have its use for pulling smaller carts and would be an advantage in the streets of Leicester being completely at home with the sights and sounds of a working urban life. In March 1900 some of the horses were sold to the War Office, presumably for use in the Boer War. These were the only horses that were ever sold at a profit; they all were sold for £50. This was quite a large sum of money considering that the most that any of the horses were bought for was £44, with £42 being the most common price. Some of the horses that were sold on were listed as lame. Occasionally mistakes were made and the horse was sold on as being 'unsuitable to our use'. Presumably such horses did not have the correct temperament, or possibly the strength and stamina for the work. Tram horses would have to have a calm temperament, a horse that panicked and bolted would be a danger to itself, the driver and passengers, and other people on the street. Occasionally a horse would bolt; one was destroyed after bolting at Aylestone terminus and suffering a broken pelvis. The destination for this horse and others who suffered terminal illnesses or fatal accidents was Mr Mason the horse slaughterer, whose business was on Wood Street; their carcasses being bought for 11 shillings.

The hard working life of the horse can be seen when looking at the reasons for which the horses were sold on. Many of the entries just state 'past our work' or 'lame all round' giving no

specific reasons. However when a disease or condition is mentioned then it is usually indicative of hard work or concussion. Conditions such as ringbone, laminitis, and lameness in the stifle are all mentioned as reasons for selling horses, and can all be brought on or exacerbated by the continual stress and concussion to the joints and feet by the constant pounding on the metalled roads.

Although the horses worked hard they were certainly fed a high-energy diet, the minutes of the Tram Company show that the food was bought from various sources in Leicester and Hull. For example at the meeting held on 2nd September 1903 it was agreed that the following could be purchased:

100 tons of hay from J Sheddon, Leicester at £4 per ton delivered
50 tons of hay from Prentice & Co. Leicester at £4 per ton delivered
30 tons of hay from Blastock & Co. Leicester at 77/6 per ton delivered
100 quarters of hale maize from W B Ridley, Hull at 21/- per 480lbs
65 quarters of kiln dried maize from C Hillerns & Co, Hull at 20/- per 480lbs
200 quarters of oats from E F Willey & Co., Hull at 21/- per 336lbs
150 quarters of oats from J Bennett & Son, Leicester at 21/- per 24 stones delivered
80 quarters of oats from T J Goodacre at 19/- per 24 stones delivered
120 quarters of oats from J Worthington, Leicester at 21/- per 24 stones delivered
200 quarters of maize from J G Lambert & Co. Hull at 21/- per 480lbs
250 quarters of maize from Everitts Ltd, Oulton Broad at 21/1 ½ per 480lbs

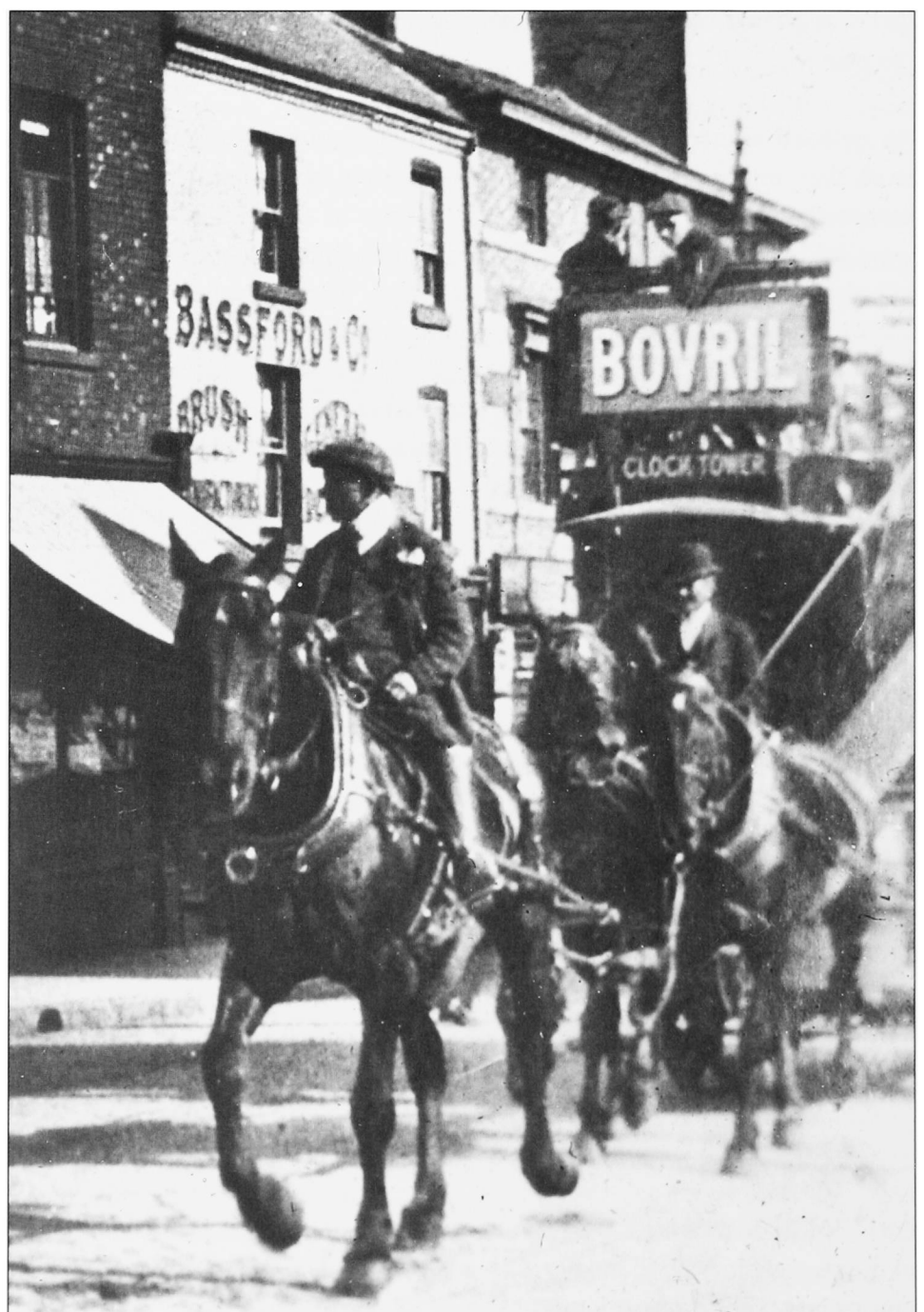
This type of diet is fed to horses in hard work and it would have provided them with a good source of energy to carry on their work; the oats and the maize providing the high-energy food and the hay the roughage vital to a horse's health and well-being. The actual amounts that the tram horses were fed do not survive in the records but there is an account in the Horse Keeper's Minute Book (7) of a recommendation that the amount of hay to be reduced to 112lbs from 168lbs and the hard feed, the maize, oats and beans to be increased as this would save money. It was also recommended that hay should be fed in racks during the day. At the same meeting it was agreed that tenders for 50 new rugs could be obtained from Mr Nixon, Messers Rodhouse & Briggs and Mr Harris. It was also stated that 13 horses had been purchased at a cost of £580 8s.0d., 13 horses had been sold for £116 11s.0d. and that one horse had died. Both the diet and the purchase of rugs for the winter do show that the horses were well cared for, but if the horses were not fit for the job then the trams

would run a delayed or reduced service and profits would be down. At the end of the day the horses were an important asset of the company, essential for keeping the transport of Leicester running efficiently, and sentimentality could not play a part.

In 1903, the year before the tracks were electrified, the Corporation owned 69 vehicles; it had carried 10,813,430 passengers over 960,934 miles and had taken £46,325 6s. 6d. (8) In 1904 the minutes of the Tramways Committee record the selling of the horses by auction, and at the meeting of 15th June 1904 it was reported that 57 horses had been sold for a total £1,122 8s. 6d. by the auctioneers Messers Whittle & Attenborough. The minutes also stated that 128 horses with their harnesses would be sold at auction by the auctioneers Messers Hincks, Shakespear and Lawrence. The horse cars and omnibuses were to be sold 'for the best price that they can obtain' At the July meeting of 1904 it was reported that another 100 horses had been sold raising 1,180 guineas. The remaining horses were to be sold equally by both firms of auctioneers. September saw another 111 horses sold, which along with 18 old cars, omnibuses and sundries made £2,175 9s. By the December meeting all the remaining horses had been sold. Listed under 'Sale of Horses and Sundries' it was reported that on 3rd November 101 horses had been sold for £1,744 1s 4d, the buses and cars for £92 13s and sundries £143 7s 7d. So as the trams finally moved over to electric traction over 250 horses had been sold, all at a loss. The era of the horse-drawn tram had come to a close in Leicester.

References and Notes:

1. *The Official Brochure of Leicester City Transport*, (c.1950). The Record Office for Leicestershire, Leicestershire and Rutland (ROLLR): L388.
2. G. G. Hilditch, *The History of Leicester City Transport*, (1984). ROLLR: L388.
3. *Leicester Tram Company Horse Register No. 2*. ROLLR: 3D62/3.
4. *Minutes of the Tramways Committee*. ROLLR: CM40/1-2.
5. A hand is 4 inches and a horse is measured to the wither or shoulder so 16 hands would be 5' 4"
6. *Leicester City Building Plans*. ROLLR: 1893/1653.
7. The horses kept at the Friday Street yard and owned by the Leicester Corporation. *Horse Keeper's Minute Book*. ROLLR: CM48.
8. *Opening of the New Administrative Offices, Abbey Park Road*, (1937). ROLLR: L388.



Three horses pulling a tram along Applegate Street around 1903. For steep hills an extra horse was put into harness to help pull the tram. (Reproduced by permission of ROLLR, location mark DE3736 Applegate Street.)